

Businesswoman **Mary Ierullo** broke a lot of new ground. She recalls her years as Realtor in our growing community of new Canadians. Through her many years of working, she had one guiding rule:

by Bob Vandenberg

Deal from the Heart

Look carefully. Its faded, but look hard on the east side of Willow and Rochester streets and you will see it.

Almost ten years after she closed her busy office, the weathered sign still proudly announces in English and Italian that Mary Ierullo is open for business. Today, she's not. But this dynamic woman, one of the first female Italian real estate brokers in Canada, is still very much a presence in her community. At 77 years of age her voice remains strong and full of conviction.

Mary closed her business in 1988 when her husband was diagnosed with cancer. But for more than 30 years, her house-front real estate office had been a hive of activity. At one time she employed 16 agents, most of them women like herself.

Her success as an independent broker was built on hard work and her offer of lower rates to help cash-strapped first-time buyers. Yet equally important to her success as a business woman was her stature in her community. She was always ready to lend a hand, provide free advice, translate some document, or offer encouragement. 'We helped each other, says Mary with a laugh. She was also a well-known figure at the courthouse, interpreting between English and Italian during cases, as well as translating for schools and churches.

She notes that she started a trend with her real estate sign by incorporating the tricolours of the Italian flag: red, white and green. As she remembers, they were the first to use the colours, but soon they started appearing on signs of Italian-owned businesses throughout the neighbourhood.

Mrs. Ierullo sold homes mostly to immigrants, predominantly Italians but also new Canadians from Portugal, Britain, Russia, Ireland, Mexico and a mix of other



origins. Later she thrived almost entirely on repeat business from satisfied customers who had also become friends. Some of her regular clients were women entrepreneurs in the area who would buy a run-down house, make it their home, and then slowly undertake repairs and upgrades. Several years later they would sell their renovated home for a small profit and start the cycle again.

Even before 1959 when Mary opened her Rochester Street office, she was a trend setter for other women in the community. She was originally attracted to starting her own business after her husband suffered a series of back injuries at the bakery where he worked.

In those days Workers Compensation only paid \$16 per month which was hardly enough to keep the Ierullo family above water. The real estate business was a challenge for Mary but most important, it meant her husband was able to work at home and avoid heavy-labour jobs which were re-injuring his back.

Today the mix of new immigrants who live in Mary's neighbourhood is different but many of the problems are the same. The difficulty of coping with an unfamiliar language, finding a good job, and being responsible for a family are still familiar struggles for many of those who come from around the globe to settle in Mary's neighbourhood.

I asked Mary what advice she could give to her younger neighbours who want to follow her example. 'Deal from the heart', she answered. 'Open up to one another and understand each other. We are part of a community and knowing each other makes all the difference.'

Look for Mary Ierullo's sign, its still there.